

Actinides

These metals are named after actinium (Ac), the first member of the group. Although this group is often shown as the bottom row in the periodic table, to save space, they actually sit between radium (Ra), an alkali earth metal, and Rutherfordium (Rf), a transition metal. All the elements in this group are radioactive, and the final nine members are artificially produced in laboratories.



Atomic structure

All the elements in this group have two electrons in their outer shell. Their atoms all have seven electron shells.



Physical properties

Natural actinides are dense metals with high melting points. The physical properties of most of the artificial ones are unknown.



Chemical properties

The actinides are reactive metals and are never found in pure form in nature. They react easily with air, the halogens, and sulfur (S).



Compounds

Actinides form colourful compounds with halogens. Most actinide ores also contain compounds of oxygen (O) called oxides.